Jargon Buster

ADF (for MFDs): An Automatic Document Feeder (ADF) lets you automatically load multiple-page documents into the scanner: you do not need to keep feeding individual pages to the scanner.

Optical Resolution: The optical resolution of a printer or scanner refers to the real hardware capabilities of the device. Nowadays, the resolution of a device can be increased by up to 8 to 9 times based on the software assisting it.

Interpolated Resolution: This is the software-enhanced resolution of the device.

Input Buffer: This is the onboard memory that a printer has, to keep a document in. It assists in speeding up the printing process when printing multiple pages.

PictBridge: This technology allows you to directly print photos from your camera onto your printer. You just connect the camera to the printer, and select the photo to be printed.

Number Of cartridges: As a thumb rule, the higher the number of cartridges, the more accurate the printout. Most high-end photo printers come with six cartridges. Besides the CMYK cartridges, they also have light cyan and light magenta.

Ink Drop Size: This is usually measured in picolitres—a trillionth of a litre. The smaller the drop size, the better the print. Manufacturers offer printers that can print drops as small as one picolitre.

PPM: This is the abbreviation for pages per minute, used to state the number of pages a printer prints in a minute.

TWAIN: TWAIN was designed to provide a universal public standard that links applications and image acquisition devices such as cameras, scanners and the like. A common misconception is that TWAIN stands for 'Technology Without An Interesting Name'. This is incorrect. It is in fact from Kipling's "The ballad of East and West"—"... and never the twain shall meet..." to show the difficulty faced, at that time, in connecting scanners and personal computers. It was capitalised to TWAIN to make it stand out. This led to the popular belief that it was an acronym.

WIA: Abbreviation for Windows Imaging Architecture, this is an interface provided natively in Microsoft Windows XP and ME enabling interaction with devices such as scanners and digital cameras.

Print Media: The contribution of printing paper towards the resulting printout is grossly underestimated. If you want to optimise your printing results, you must use suitable media. Today, in the market, you probably have more of a choice with print media than printers!

Paper sizes that are available will cater to every need you could think of. There is a multitude of brands to choose from. The more popular ones are Kodak, Novajet, and Berga. The quality of the paper is dependant on its density, which is measured in g/sm (grams per square metre). As a thumb rule, the higher the g/sm, the better the paper quality.

Photo papers are classified into photo paper, glossy photo paper and matte photo paper, depending on the kind of finish you are looking for. You can get an A4-size 15-sheet pack of 275 g/sm Kodak photo paper for approximately Rs 200.

Print Requirement	Print Media	Approximate Cost
Regular everyday printing	70-80 g/sm paper	Rs 125 for 500 sheets
High Quality text prints (résumés, applications etc)	100-120 g/sm paper	
Normal photo prints	170-210 g/sm photo paper	Rs 200 for 20 sheets
High quality photo prints	270+ g/sm photo paper	Rs 200 for 15 sheets

CD Printing

A lot of the mid to high-end printers today support CD/DVD printing. They come with a special attachment tray where you can print any image you choose on the CD/DVD. This feature makes your compilations look professional. To do this, you need to have a printer that supports this, and a CD/DVD with a printable coating. If your CD/DVD media does not have that coating, you can print the image on paper and literally cut and paste it onto your CD!

In terms of scanning features, not all MFDs had flatbed scanners, and some, like the Brother 3240c and the HP OfficeJet 4255, had a sheet-fed scanner that made multiple-document scanning an inconvenient task. But the HP 4255 had the advantage of being extremely compact in design. The Brother MFD, thanks to the sheet-fed scanner, was also bulky as such devices normally are.

On the other hand, the Brother MFDs sorely lacked build quality. The cheap plastic was quite obvious even without opening the box!

Performance
Printing

The HP MFDs really shone in our text document speed test. The fastest time was clocked by the HP PSC 1608 at 16.68 seconds. The runner-up was another HP, the HP PSC 2310 at 17 seconds. Not quick by any standards—the Canon Pixma iP 1000 did the same document in seven seconds—still pretty respectable. The fastest non-HP device was the Brother 3240C at 23 seconds with its sibling, the 210C, clocking 25.5 seconds. As in the printer tests, the Epson stylus CX 1500 brought up the rear with 37 seconds!

So if you believe the bulk of your printing requirements would be text documents, the HP PSC 1608 is the fastest, and is nearly the most economical—second only to the Lexmark X7170.

In the next stage, we put the printers through our combi-doc test. Surprisingly, the Brother MFC 3240C outshone others, printing the document in merely 46 seconds. It was followed closely by the HP PSC 2310 at 48 seconds. The Lexmark X7170 took a leisurely 78 seconds, with the Epson CX1500 in the bottom spot again with 253 seconds.

Although we are not really looking at the photo printing capabilities of the devices in this section, it never hurts to print the occasional office picnic photo, right? In our photo printing tests, the fastest printer was the HP PSC 2310 which printed the A4-sized image in a respectable 289 seconds. The Lexmark X7170 did the same job in about 375 seconds, while Epson (yes, again) with 1,159 (you read that right!) seconds was last.

It must be mentioned here that the Brother MFDs did not fare too well, with the MFC 3240 and 210 clocking above 1,000 seconds each! If you want to print a picture

Epson Stylus PHOTO CX1500